

Australia Daily Brief

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AUSTRALIA · NEW ZEALAND · THE PACIFIC ISLANDS

Wednesday, September 9, 2026

RE: Nauru NZYQ deal published, AU\$2.5B over 30 years · Solomon Islands opposition alleges Australian interference · Wong holds out on settlement import ban · NZ public servants strike · Brent tops \$100 after US tanker strikes

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ASX 200

8,911

-0.75%

AUD/USD

0.7219

+0.77%

NZX 50

13,819

-0.80%

NZD/USD

0.5840

-0.19%

TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Canberra published the terms of its NZYQ deportation agreement with Nauru, confirming the AU\$2.5 billion, thirty-year price first disclosed in August 2025, while Greens senator David Shoebridge said a companion financial memorandum is still being withheld.
- 2 Solomon Islands' Opposition accused Australia's High Commission of foreign interference after a leaked text to Deputy Prime Minister Francis Sade surfaced as a no-confidence motion against Prime Minister Matthew Wale was withdrawn and a billion-dollar treaty package was agreed in principle.
- 3 New Zealand public servants walked off the job over a pay offer, Reuters reported, two months before the 7 November general election.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Solomon Islands Opposition accuses Australia of foreign interference

Solomon Islands' Opposition said communication between the Australian High Commission and Deputy Prime Minister Francis Sade was "deeply concerning" and appeared to show Australian funding being used to influence the outcome of a no-confidence motion against Prime Minister Matthew Wale. Sade rejected the claim, saying the text was an update on successful treaty negotiations. The motion was withdrawn as talks wrapped up, with Australia agreeing in principle to a billion-dollar package. Lowy Institute research fellow Oliver Nobetau said recent bilateral agreements share language on denying strategic access to third parties.

per ABC News: "Solomon Islands Opposition accuses Australia of foreign interference"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Wong criticised by former colleague for skipping Israeli settlement trade ban

A former Labor colleague called Foreign Minister Penny Wong "cowardly" for declining to join the British-led crackdown on imports from Israeli settlements in the occupied West Bank, while Israel's ambassador applauded Canberra for standing aside. The United Kingdom, France and Canada said in a joint statement that rising settler violence poses a "direct and urgent threat" to a two-state solution. Wong said Australia is not pursuing a blanket import ban. Israel is forcing the closure of the British Consulate in occupied East Jerusalem in retaliation.

per SMH (Matthew Knott): "'Cowardly': Wong slammed by former colleague for dodging Israeli settlement trade ban" · also ABC News

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Australia releases NZYQ deportation agreement with Naoero

The Australian government published the agreement to deport more than 350 refugees and asylum seekers, the "NZYQ cohort", to Naoero, formerly Nauru. Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke said in August 2025 that the deal gave Naoero AU\$2.5 billion over thirty years. Greens senator David Shoebridge said the release only scratches the surface and that the government continues to resist producing a separate memorandum setting up the financial arrangement. Australia turned to Naoero after the High Court's late-2023 NZYQ ruling.

per RNZ Pacific: "'New level of bastardry': Australia releases NZYQ agreement with Naoero"

OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

Lockheed Martin wins Air 6500 Tranche 2B contract — Lockheed Martin has been awarded the Air 6500 Tranche 2B contract for Australia's joint air battle management system, Australian Defence Magazine reported. The report carried no contract value or delivery schedule. Air 6500 is the integrated air and missile defence command and control program named in successive Australian defence planning documents. · Australian Defence Magazine

US-AUSTRALIA

Joyce warns digital duty of care bill risks a clash with Washington — Barnaby Joyce said the Albanese government's big tech crackdown is "clumsy" and risks provoking American anger, The Australian reported. The bill would let the government require platforms to notify users and offer them the choice of opting out of algorithmic feeds. Prime Minister Anthony Albanese dismissed censorship concerns about the bill as "disingenuous" as divisions opened in the Coalition over the policy. · The Australian

AU-POLITICS

Albanese and Taylor hold direct talks on migration — Opposition Leader Angus Taylor took a suite of migration demands directly to the Prime Minister, The Australian reported, with Labor eyeing a low-key policy release. Opposition MPs are wary of any perception the Coalition would back Labor on migration, which would feed Pauline Hanson's line about a Labor-Coalition "uni-party", according to the Sydney Morning Herald. · The Australian

TRADE-ECONOMY

Student visa refusals hit a ten-year high of 24.2 percent — Department of Home Affairs data shows the student visa refusal rate rose from 7.9 percent in June 2016 to 24.2 percent in June 2026. More than 51 percent of applications from Nepal were rejected in 2025-2026 and more than 40 percent from India, against 5.8 percent from China. One Indonesian applicant told the ABC her application, including a 27-page statement, was refused within a day. · ABC News

STAT OF THE DAY

AU\$2.5 billion

Paid to Naoero over 30 years under the NZYQ deal

The figure, first disclosed by Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke in August 2025, frames the newly released agreement to deport more than 350 people.

RNZ Pacific

PACIFIC WIRE

KIRIBATI · ABC NEWS

More than 300 WWII ordnance destroyed on Betio Island

Operation Pakodua destroyed more than 300 unexploded ordnance on Betio Island over the weekend, following years of planning with the New Zealand Defence Force. NZDF Lieutenant Colonel Cameron Wright, the operation's senior national officer, said local authorities were also trained to handle munitions surfacing as infrastructure is excavated. An RNZAF C-130J flew the equipment into Tarawa, the site of a 76-hour battle in which more than 6,000 soldiers died.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

Northern Ambae communities in water crisis after volcanic ashfall

Communities in northern Ambae are without clean drinking water after renewed eruption of the Manaro Voui volcano covered existing water sources in ash following months of dry weather. Chief Antoine Vuti of Nangire Village told reporter Leah Lowonbu that residents are trucking drinking water from other parts of the island, and that ash in the water is driving persistent coughing, particularly among children.

◦ NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

New Zealand public servants walk off job over pay offer

New Zealand public servants stopped work over a pay offer, Reuters reported. The industrial action comes with the general election set for 7 November and advance voting opening 26 October.

NZ-POLITICS · PACIFIC MEDIA NETWORK

Pacific student attendance rises in Aotearoa while belonging falls

Pacific Media Network reported that Pacific student attendance in New Zealand schools is rising even as measures of belonging decline. Pacific communities are among the fastest-growing electorates in the country ahead of the November vote.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

PALAU · SENIOR VISIT · EIN PRESSWIRE

China's Pacific envoy Qian Bo attended the 55th Forum Leaders Meeting

A Chinese government statement confirms that Qian Bo, Special Envoy for Pacific Island Countries Affairs, attended the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting, held in Koror. Leaders at that meeting agreed a two-tier dialogue partner system and the Belau Declaration, according to the Development Policy Centre.

◦ CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Hastie calls Hanson and Joyce "lying cowards" over "traitor" video

Opposition frontbencher Andrew Hastie demanded One Nation delete or own a video describing him as a "traitor" over his evidence in the 2022 Ben Roberts-Smith defamation trial. Pauline Hanson said she had never called him a traitor but refused to delete the material; Barnaby Joyce confirmed the claim appeared in a satirical cartoon he had not seen. One Nation is targeting Hastie's Western Australian seat at the next election.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Reset Tech links AI deepfake network of 200-plus pages to a Sri Lankan business

Reset Tech tracked more than 200 Facebook pages impersonating Anthony Albanese, Angus Taylor, Pauline Hanson and other figures over eight months, linking the network to an influencer business in Sri Lanka. Roughly 10 percent of the pages were monetised under Facebook's creator payment scheme. Chief research officer Rys Farthing said "this isn't foreign interference as we traditionally think of it".

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Albanese calls censorship concerns over duty of care bill "disingenuous"

The Prime Minister dismissed censorship criticism of Labor's digital duty of care bill and faced questions over an undeclared honorary membership at the Marrickville Golf Club, which received \$6 million through an invite-only grant scheme. Domestic, Family and Sexual Violence Commissioner Micaela Cronin's annual report, tabled the same day, warned government policy has not meaningfully reduced rates of sexual violence.

◦ BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · WSJ

Australian second-quarter growth beats expectations as RBA turns hawkish

Australia's second-quarter growth came in stronger than expected, the Wall Street Journal reported, and a separate WSJ analysis said hawkish Reserve Bank commentary has lit the fuse for a September rate increase. The cash rate has been held at 4.35 percent since 11 August. The ASX 200 closed at 8,911, down 0.75 percent, with the Australian dollar at 0.7219, up 0.77 percent.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Brent passes \$100 as US destroys Iranian tankers and Iran strikes back

US Central Command destroyed five Iranian oil tankers, including the Riesco, and Iran's Revolutionary Guard fired ballistic missiles at a base near Al Azraq in Jordan and attacked 10 ships in the Strait of Hormuz. Jordan's military said it intercepted 18 missiles. Brent settled at 100.57, up 5.29 percent. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said every attempt on US ships would cost Iran tankers.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

WA regulator moves to change Chinese-owned miner's licence over Geraldton dust

Western Australia's Department of Water and Environmental Regulation found magnetite from industrial activity is contributing to dust polluting homes and businesses around Geraldton, and said it will meet the Mid West Ports Authority and Chinese-owned Karara Mining to change operating licence conditions. Uncovered iron ore trains run about 200 kilometres to the port daily.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Analysts tip home price falls of up to 15 percent

Analysts expect Australian home prices to fall by as much as 15 percent in what The Australian described as the biggest rout since the 1980s, as the downturn accelerates alongside expectations of further rate rises.

○ UPCOMING

Oct
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Early voting starts with the public sector pay dispute unresolved.

Nov
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it Winston Peters' Pacific and Foreign Affairs agenda.

date not
announced 2026

First test of the Pacific Islands Forum's two-tier dialogue partner model, at a Forum event in New Zealand

Sets the operating precedent for how partners including China, the United States and Taiwan engage the Forum.

cyclone season
ahead 2026

Pacific tropical cyclone season preparations

Forum members are readying warning systems as El Nino conditions are forecast to persist into 2027.

expected 2027

El Nino impacts on the Pacific forecast to last well into 2027

Extends drought and water-security stress of the kind now hitting northern Ambae in Vanuatu.

○ THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

Australia must defend its will to fight, not just its infrastructure

The national civil preparedness and resilience inquiry, adopted in July, is framed as the opening for a public conversation on societal resilience rather than physical hardening alone. · ASPI Strategist

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

UN General Assembly adopts Equal Earth projection, enlarging Australia and Africa

The General Assembly approved an "equal area" map to replace the Mercator projection in UN usage, on a proposal introduced by Togo for 54 African countries. Togolese Foreign Affairs Minister Robert Dussey said correcting the map addresses an "imbalance inherited from the past". · ABC News

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Wellington's PNG community marks Tok Pisin Language Week

Papua New Guinea's community in Wellington marked Tok Pisin Week, with community president Ancey Waimiri saying the events also build towards Papua New Guinea's 51st independence anniversary. · ABC Pacific

TRADE-ECONOMY

Tax take across Australian governments up 60 percent since Covid to \$893 billion

Combined federal, state and territory revenue has risen 60 percent since the pandemic to \$893 billion, The Australian reported, as the Coalition presses a costed tax package. · The Australian

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AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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